



Apple beefs up security

Adds two-step verification for Apple IDs, ensuring you verify your identity using one of your devices. <http://dgit.in/10qHelP>

Search for Antimatter

Is antimatter for real or is it some scientist's fascination? Here's what we learn about this unknown phenomenon. <http://dgit.in/14gt9Lq>

Laptops Test

HOW WE TESTED

Not just for this comparison test, but this is how we generally test laptops for reviews conducted throughout the year in the magazine and on the website. The idea is to keep the testing pattern exactly the same, so that no one machine has an unfair advantage over the other.

Prepping

We never benchmark a laptop's performance with the way the OS and the software is, out of the box. All preloaded software on the machine, including any security software trials and other bloatware, is uninstalled – to ensure that none of the pre-bundled software has any effect on the laptop's performance score. Then come the download and installation of the latest patches and drivers from Windows Update or the manufacturer website, Bios update and

any critical patches the manufacturer may have released.

Benchmarking

A range of industry standard software benchmarks are run to measure a laptop's hardware capability and overall performance – PC Mark 07, 3D Mark 06, 3D Mark 11 and CineBench are some examples of the benchmarks used to test and compare laptops. A series of tests check the display quality too, testing aspects such as contrast, black and white levels. We limit subjectivity as far as possible, so as to remove any chances of personal bias or preconceived notions coming in the way of a fair review. Battery tests are done with the machine at full load, and the display always on at full brightness. For most real-world usage patterns, expect 70% to 100% more backup time.

Ergonomics

While look and feel can be a matter of personal preference to some extent, determining the best ergonomic design is a matter of scientific principles. In determining the Design & Usability score for every laptop, we take into account several factors such as build quality, materials used, quality and placement of hinges, keyboard usage (quality and feel as well as comfort), palmrest real estate, touchpad response quality, etc. and break it down exhaustively to arrive at a cumulative score for ergonomics, design and general usability aspects of the laptop. After going through this process for each and every laptop, we arrive at a final score based on a formula with assigned weighted scores for performance, design and features.

some surprising observations to report. While these may be considered “budget” or “affordable”, the quality of materials used and the way the machines were put together is rather impressive. Compared to the shoddy build quality and the complete neglect to basic stuff like port placement and quality of materials in the not too recent past, this development would delight the buyers. However, there are still one or two examples still stuck to the old “affordable means compromise” logic.

The HP Pavilion G6 laptops, while they have different configurations, have exactly the same build and design, albeit in different colours. The G6-2301ax has the black finish, with a dash of glossiness, while the G6-2227u has a rather interesting white colour option. The black, glossy finish means that you'll either be taking a cloth to the machine every few hours to ensure it remains fingerprint, dust and grime free, or end up with a laptop that looks old within a week of buying it. The

keyboard has the island layout, and we really like the experience – be it key size, travel (the distance needed to push the key to enter a character reliably) or response. The touchpad has separate right and left click keys. Its textured design could be slightly annoying with the inconsistent response in cer-

tain conditions, particularly when your finger might be a tad sweaty in the summers. Both machines come across as thick, but are not as heavy as you would first expect them to be. Plastic is used all around, but of fairly good quality. For an affordable laptop to not have any flex anywhere on the chassis,

including no dip in the middle of the keyboard, is a huge deal. The HP G6 series of laptops have taken care of this aspect.

The Acer Aspire V5-571-323 is possibly the most impressive in terms of overall look and usability. Quite frankly, the materials used and the overall finish is deserving of a laptop that may be priced much higher than this one. This is the slimmest of the lot, discounting the Asus VivoBook for a second, and yet retains an optical drive. The keyboard is a tad too spaced out, and takes time getting used to. However, typing a document quickly won't be a problem once you do.

Like the HP G6 notebooks, the Toshiba M840 and the C850 won't win any contests attempting to determine the slimmest notebooks. While the M840's shiny colour options on the lid may not appeal to everyone, the C850 evens things out with a more sophisticated design. They both have good build quality, but in terms of that X factor, these Toshiba machines seem to be missing



Asus VivoBook F202e - CT148H